POU11011 — Short assignment: the blog post

30% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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Weight	30% of the module mark
Length	800 words, +/- 10%. Outside that range costs up to 5 marks
Format	A blog post, not an academic essay
Due	**Friday 23 October 2026, 23:59**
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), with the Assignment Submission Form as page 1
Sources	At least two module readings

The task

Answer one of the three prompts below. Each names one idea from the module; use it to make sense of one real political situation.

One concept, one case. A post that takes, for example, extractive capacity seriously is better than one that tries to tackle the state, ideology and identity in the very limited space you have.

What a blog post is

Less formal than an essay and freer in structure, but still an argument backed by evidence.

- Open on the case, not with "In this blog post, I will argue…"
- Use short paragraphs, headings and bold text where they help
- Links are welcome. Up to three images, each with a caption and its source
- First person is fine
- References are still required: at least two module readings, in any consistent referencing style (the TCD Library guide helps)
- Academic sources must come from the module's readings. News and other sources are fine as evidence, but don't count toward the two
- "Module readings" means anything on the syllabus reading lists, required or recommended. Two different chapters of Heywood & Laing count as two; lecture slides don't count
- A link doesn't replace a reference to a module reading

Examples of the genre: LSE blogs, The Conversation, Good Authority.

One structure that works

1. **The case.** What happened, and what is puzzling about it.
2. **Your claim.** One sentence, early.
3. **The concept.** Name it, define it, and cite where it comes from.
4. **The analysis.** Apply the concept in two or three steps, each tied to a specific detail of the case. Most of the marks are here.
5. **The limits.** What the concept does not explain about this case.

There are lots of structures you can go with, though. You don't have to be limited to these suggestions.

The prompts

Your case can come from any country, as long as it is from after the year 2000. Choose your own, or one of the examples under each prompt.

Prompt A — The state

Choose a state in the news. Using **state capacity**, and distinguishing coercive, extractive and administrative capacity, explain one thing that state is failing, or managing, to do. What does the case show about why capacity is not one number?

Examples: Mexico and the drug cartels; tax collection in Nigeria; Estonia's digital state.

Prompt B — Ideology

Choose a live policy fight. Using the three questions every ideology answers (**who should get what, what people are like, how change should happen**), show how **two** of **liberalism**, **conservatism** and **socialism** would answer it differently: the serious versions, not the caricatures. Then argue which part of the disagreement could be settled by evidence, and which part can't.

Examples: Berlin's 2020 rent freeze; a wealth tax; free university tuition. Whichever you choose, tie it to one country at one moment.

Prompt C — Identity

Choose a political identity that matters somewhere. Is it better explained as **inherited** (primordialism), **built** (constructivism), or **switched on by politicians** (instrumentalism)? Argue for one.

Examples: Catalan identity and the 2017 independence referendum; "Leavers" and "Remainers" in Britain after 2016; Hindu nationalism and the consecration of the Ram temple at Ayodhya in 2024.

How it is marked

Five criteria: **argument, use of concepts, evidence, structure and writing, referencing**. For this piece, use of concepts and evidence count most.

Common problems

- Describing the concept instead of using it
- Too many concepts
- No case, or a case the size of a continent ("democracy in Europe")
- A formal essay with headings added
- Citing a newspaper article as an academic source: this is evidence but not scholarship

Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the categories of the Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine.
Brainstorming	**Not permitted.** Choosing the case and the angle is part of the assignment.
Research/learning assistance	**Permitted for one thing only:** clarifying a concept or passage from the readings that you could not follow after genuinely trying. Not for finding a case, finding sources, or summarising readings.
Writing assistance	**Permitted only for spelling and grammar** in sentences you wrote, the kind of correction Word makes. Not for rewording, restructuring or tone.
Direct AI content inclusion	**Not permitted.**
Other use	**Not permitted.**

Submission

- You don't need your name on the post itself: the submission form carries your details.
- State your word count at the top. Headings, quotations and image captions count toward it; links, images and the reference list don't.
- A submission without the Assignment Submission Form (on Blackboard, in Word and PDF) is treated as not submitted until you resubmit with one. The form doesn't count toward the word limit.
- Submit early enough to survive a technical problem, and keep the receipt.

Late work and extensions: see the module outline.